SIX

Count Forwards

NELL · DAY 23,228 · TUESDAY 19 MAY 2026

THE COMMENTS STARTED just after two in the morning, and I was awake for all of them.

They came from an account with no picture, called **@longweather_**, and they were long: whole paragraphs, fluent and patient and sure of themselves. They knew the neighbourhood's troubles as well as Danny did. Rents. Bills. The jobs that had gone. The meter keys in the queue. For a sentence or two they sounded almost like him, and that was the worst part, because then every one of them turned, without a seam, and came to rest in the same place: on a group of ordinary people, people you might live next door to, who were apparently to blame for all of it. It didn't matter where a comment started. It always ended pointing down the street.

I'm not going to repeat them. I deleted them. They kept coming, every nine or ten minutes, and I kept deleting them, and somewhere around the fifth I noticed my hands were cold.

The sixth used my name. Not Vesper. *Nell*. Danny's comment had been up eight days, and this was the first thing to pick it up and use it.

I looked the account up. It had existed since 2022, years before my blog. Somebody had chosen the words *long weather* long before I'd found them stamped in purple on a sheet of paper in a box.

The seventh comment was different. It was shorter, and it was about me.

It didn't threaten anything. It mentioned, in passing, halfway through a sentence about something else, that I'd *stood at the shelves for an hour and forty minutes, on the Tuesday*. Then it went back to blaming the people down the street.

I had. Tuesday the twenty-first of April, the 1971 logs, the ledger open on my forearm because I hadn't wanted to sit down and waste the time. I'd never written how long I was there. I'd never said it. I hadn't known it myself until I read it, and then I knew it was right, because I remembered the light going in the high window and the time on my phone when I came out.

I told myself it was a guess. I'm a reconciler. I know what a guess looks like.

I deleted it, and then sat looking at the gap where it had been until the comments stopped, at a quarter to four, as if whoever it was had gone to bed.

At seven I sent Danny a screenshot of the seventh. He rang back from the van.

"Keep deleting them," he said. "And don't read them at night."

"It knew how long I was in there."

A pause, with the indicator ticking in it.

"Then keep the door locked as well," he said, and I could hear him trying to make it sound like a joke, and not managing.

* * *

SATURDAY 23 MAY

THE LETTER CAME on the Saturday, in among a pizza menu and a charity bag and something from the council about bins.

A plain white envelope, second-class stamp, the postmark smudged to a grey thumbprint. My full name and my address,

typed. Not *Nell*, which anyone could have by now. All of it. And my home address, which has never been on the blog or anything else of mine that I could find. I looked, that evening, for a long time.

One sheet, folded twice. It had been typed on a real typewriter: under the kitchen light you could see where each key had bitten into the page, the capitals pressed deeper than the full stops. Across the top ran a thin band of grey, the colour of a sky that hasn't decided whether to rain. No letterhead. No sender. No date.

I'll set it down exactly as it is.

MS OKAFOR-REYES.

YOU COUNTED BACKWARDS. GOOD. NOW COUNT FORWARDS.

3062 DAYS OUT. THAT WAS THE MACHINE LEAVING HARROWGATE.

228XX DAYS IN. YOU WILL KNOW WHICH DAY.

THE MACHINE THAT LEFT THAT HOUSE WEIGHED 144 LB. ASK WHAT CAME TO YOUR DESK. ASK WHAT IT WEIGHS.

I HAVE BEEN IN YOUR ACCOUNT. I AM SORRY. YOUR PASSWORD WAS YOUR FATHERS BIRTHDAY. YOU SHOULD CHANGE IT. YOU SHOULD ALSO ASK WHY I KNOW IT.

DO NOT BLAME ANYONE YOU CAN SEE FROM YOUR WINDOW. THAT IS WHAT THEY WANT.

WHEN YOU ARE READY THE DOOR IS GREY.

It wasn't signed. At the foot of the page was a small drawing in black ink of a chair: a plain wooden kitchen chair, the kind every family I grew up with had four of, slightly mismatched. Through it, one clean line.

Yes. My password had been my father's birthday. He'd have been disappointed in me, though not surprised.

I opened the laptop and did the one thing I'd never thought to do, which was look at the blog's own history. It keeps a record of every time anyone signs in. You'd no more check it than you'd check the guest book in your own house.

There was one line I hadn't made. *Friday 1 May. 03:12. Signed in. Drafts opened. Signed out, 03:19.*

The night of my second post. Seven minutes in my drafts folder, where I kept the things I didn't publish: Len's face in the café, *Who else did you tell?*, the man at the next table, half a page about my father that I'd never finish. Somebody had sat in the dark and read all of it, and changed nothing, and left.

I changed my password. Then every password I've ever had, which took the rest of the afternoon. And somewhere in the middle of it, typing a new one with my teeth clenched, I understood the thing that frightened me more than the letter.

The Tuesday wasn't in my drafts. I'd never written down how long I stood at those shelves. Whoever had been in my account at 03:12 couldn't have told @longweather_. Someone else knew.

Two of them, then. One who wrote to me in capitals and said sorry. And one who didn't need to get in at all.

* * *

228XX DAYS IN.

Day 0 was the fourteenth of October, 1962. I counted forwards on the back of the council letter about bins, because that's who I am. Day 22,800 fell on Monday the seventeenth of March, 2025. Day 22,899 fell on Tuesday the twenty-fourth of June.

Fourteen weeks, then. Somewhere in those fourteen weeks, a day I would know.

I didn't have to look for it. It was in there the way a stone is in a shoe.

Saturday, 17 May 2025. Day 22,861. The croissants. The man with the lanyard and the clicker. Nine of us round a boardroom table in weekend clothes, and the amber dots beginning to move

across the map. *It's live. As of this morning.*

Somebody had put a machine leaving that house in 1971 and the system that replaced me on the same line of arithmetic, fifty-four years apart, like two entries in one ledger. And they'd been so sure I'd find the day that they hadn't bothered to tell me which it was.

Last Sunday had been a year to the day. I'd spent it on my own and told nobody what day it was. I'd thought I was the only one keeping count.

ASK WHAT CAME TO YOUR DESK. ASK WHAT IT WEIGHS.

I knew what had come to my desk. Nothing had. That was the point. What came was a grey cabinet in the comms room at head office, the size of a small wardrobe, with a fan you could hear through the wall. The routing system's local box. We used to joke it was our replacement, back when it was something you could joke about. I'd walked past it a hundred times.

I had no idea what it weighed.

* * *

I WENT TO the window because the letter had told me to, in its way. *Do not blame anyone you can see from your window.* I'd read it as a warning. Standing there, I started to read it as an instruction to look.

It was early evening and the street was doing what streets do. Graham opposite was out on his step watering his hanging basket, a ridiculous explosion of fuchsias that drips on the postman. He has a grey front door. I'd lived across from it for six years and never once noticed what colour it was.

Further down, the young mother from the food bank queue was wrestling her pushchair over the kerb that's too high for push-chairs. Two lads from the estate sat on the wall outside the shop, laughing at a phone. At the end of the road, if I leaned, I could see the corner of the block with the plywood window, and I knew without seeing it that the rainbow was still there.

And a man was walking a dog.

A small brown terrier on a short lead, trotting at heel. I didn't know him. I know most of the dog people on my road by their dogs if not their faces, and I'd never seen this one. He walked the length of the street on the far side at an even pace, and the dog didn't stop at a single lamppost, which a dog always does, and he didn't look up. Everybody looks up at a lit window, just for a second, without meaning to. He didn't. He went past Graham, past the shop, past the lads, and round the corner, and he never once looked at my side of the street, as if he already knew exactly what was in it.

Ordinary people. Tired people. People who'd been told, every day, by every screen they owned, which of the others to be afraid of.

Do not blame anyone you can see from your window. That is what they want.

I'd heard that sentence before. Danny, at this same window, a week ago: *Don't let anyone tell you it's the people down your street.*

And for one second the thought came in, like cold under a door. Danny knew where I lived. Danny had known my father's birthday for thirty years; he'd eaten half the cake at most of them. Danny had said it first.

I said "No," out loud, to the empty flat.

I stood at the window until Graham went in and the street lights came on, and I didn't blame anyone. It took effort, and I hadn't known it would.

* * *

MONDAY 25 MAY

ON MONDAY I took the keycard back.

I told myself that was why I was going. Coyle's head office is a glass box on a business park, twenty minutes on the bus, with a car park three-quarters empty since the transition. I'd been planning what to say to whoever was on reception: that I'd found it in a coat,

that I was sorry, that nobody had asked.

Nobody was on reception. There was a tablet on a stand that said *Welcome! Please sign in*, and a bowl of mints, and a plant that was either very healthy or plastic.

I held the card up, the way you do when you're about to hand something over and there's no one to hand it to. Then, because there was no one, I touched it to the reader on the inner door.

It beeped. Green.

My notice had ended twenty-five days before. My laptop had gone back, my phone, my lanyard, my parking permit. Payroll had sent me my P45. And the door to the corridor opened for me as if I'd only been out for lunch.

I should have left the card on the desk next to the mints. I know that. Instead I walked down the corridor I'd walked every working day for years, past the planners' room, where there used to be nine of us and was now one man in headphones who didn't turn round, to the door at the end with no sign on it.

The comms room. I'd never once had a reason to go in.

I touched the card to the reader. Green.

It was cold inside, and loud with fans, and the grey cabinet stood against the far wall exactly where I'd always pictured it through the plasterboard: chest-high, featureless, a row of small lights on its door going about their business. In the corner, above the door I'd come in by, a camera. Its red light was on.

On the side of the cabinet, near the floor, there was a metal plate, riveted on, the kind nobody reads: a serial number, a voltage, a date of manufacture. I crouched down to it. It's what I do. I read the small print on things.

NET WT 65 KG.

And underneath, for the export market, in smaller letters:

144 LB.

I stayed crouched there long enough for my knees to hurt. The cabinet hummed. It was a deep, steady sound, felt as much as heard, and I thought, before I could stop myself, of Len saying

hummed with the power off.

When I stood up, the red light was still on. It was the only thing in the room looking at me.

I left the way I'd come. I didn't run. The man in headphones didn't turn round. I walked past the tablet and the mints and the plant and out into the car park, and it was only at the bus stop that I found the keycard still in my hand, warm from holding it.

I'd forgotten to hand it in. That's what I told myself.

* * *

THAT NIGHT I sat at the kitchen table with the letter and the grey band catching the light, and asked the question it had told me to ask.

You should also ask why I know it.

My father worked at Coyle's head office for thirty years. *Ask Emmanuel*, people said, and he'd tell you the shelf, the box and the colour of the folder. He was kind. He was quiet. He did the crossword every evening in pen, which he said was the only arrogant thing about him, and as far as I knew he never kept a secret in his life.

As far as I knew.

Len had said the office would ring the drivers at home, the night before one of those runs.

The office would ring.

I got up. I didn't decide to. I found myself at the shelf with my hand on my father's crossword dictionary, the spine broken in three places from forty years of opening at the same letters.

I took it down. It fell open by itself at the pages he'd used most, and there in the margins, in his small upright pencil, were his marks: a tick here, a dot there, a word underlined, a number written very small beside a clue I'd never see.

I could have read them. They were right there. I'm a reconciler. Reading what other people wrote in the margins is the thing I'm for.

I closed it. I put it back on the shelf with the spine facing out, as he always had.

Some things you count. And some things you leave on the shelf, so that for one more night the man who knew where everything was is still just your father, finishing the crossword, in pen.